finest example of a purely Hindu temple in India' – lay derelict and overgrown by thick jungle. Photographs taken by the ASI in the 1860s and 1870s and those published by Rajendralal Mitra in his *Antiquities of Orissa* in 1875 show how extensive this dilapidation was. In the circumstances it is easy to see why Colin Mackenzie and General Charles 'Hindu' Stuart – whose Hindu statues now make up a large portion of the British Museum's outstanding collection[3] – felt free to help themselves to a number of stone images, in particular those from the niches of the Raja Rani temple.

When Stirling toured the temples in the early 1820s he noted that one, known as the Bhaskareshwara shrine, had been built around a large 40-foot stone column. However, when the Bhaskareshwara temple was next reported on, by Rajendralal Mitra in the 1880s, the column had shrunk to a mere 9 feet. Even so, Mitra had no hesitation in declaring it to be Ashokan in origin, which appeared to be confirmed when in 1929 the head and shoulders of an Ashokan-type lion capital were found in a pit beside the temple, followed by the discovery of an Ashokan bell (base of a capital) and fragments of a pillar in an old tank known locally as the 'Asoka jhara' or 'Asoka kund'. What had apparently begun as an Ashokan-style pillar, probably standing beside a Buddhist stupa, had been converted into a Shaiva linga and a temple built around it.